The Bonn Visit

The moment that had already been so elaborately labelled as historic by the West German media, began at 08.00 on 7 September 1987 at Bonn airport. Under a bright sky, Honecker was welcomed to West Germany with pomp and ceremony as the Bundeswehr band played the East German national anthem ‘Auferstanden aus Ruinen’ and a military honour guard gave the salute.

Although officially described as a ‘working visit’, the SED leader was afforded all the protocol honours of a state visitor, making Germany’s two-state identity clearly visible throughout the world. At a special lunch, Federal President Weizsäcker welcomed his guest as a ‘German among Germans’ and called for further ‘system-opening cooperation’.

That same night at dinner, using road-tested language, Honecker urged the FRG to accept the reality of two German nations, warning against ‘sweet dreams’ of reunification. In response, Kohl summed up the issue in a nutshell, saying on fundamental points: ‘We are as far apart as ever. No one could expect anything else.’ Concluding his speech, he added: ‘I want to say once again on behalf of the federal government – we are firm about the unity of the German nation.’ In closing, Kohl called for an end to the shooting of would-be escapees from East German territory. Honecker, meanwhile, sat silent.

The trip continued with a visit to North Rhine-Westphalia, followed by a journey to Essen to meet with leading representatives of the FRG economy. The following morning, Honecker was in Trier being feted by Minister-President of Rhineland-Palatinate Bernhard Vogel.

On the final leg of the trip, though, policy took a back seat for a jubilant visit to the Saarland and a pilgrimage to his childhood home. He travelled by motorcade to Neunkirchen, where he stopped in Wiebelskirchen district to meet his younger sister, 70-year-old Gertrud, before visiting the graves of